

CRISIS AND displacement

REFUGEES AND ASYLUM SEEKERS

Since 1945, the global refugee crisis has been at the forefront of contemporary political debate in Europe and the US. Refugees, over the course of the 20th century, have left their homes to escape from war, political disorder, persecution, and natural disasters. The most significant events to trigger refugee crises were World War II and decolonization (see pp. 246–247), the aftermath of the Cold War, and upheaval in the Middle East (especially in Iraq and Syria) toward the end of the 20th century. Today, women and children make up at least 50 percent of refugees, and in some cases outnumber men: of the refugees fleeing Syria today, more than 70 percent are women and children—both groups are especially vulnerable to violence and exploitation.

Defining refuge

The refugee agency the United Nations High Commissioner for Refugees was created in 1950 in response to the refugee crisis caused by World War II (see pp. 234–237). In 1951, the United Nations Refugee Convention created a legal framework for dealing with European refugees, and in 1967, responding to the demand from anti-colonial groups and newly independent countries, the Refugee

▼ Displaced childhood

Betty Malek, aged three, arrives with her belongings and toys in London from Antwerp in May, 1940, after her city was bombed by German planes.

